Honecker was also able to furnish Brezhnev with plans of a hastily contrived GDR–Czech plan to produce a new ‘peoples’ car’ at two plants in East Germany and the Skoda works in Prague. Although the project was dropped, production of the infamous two-stroke Trabant – one of the greatest polluters ever to hit the road – was stepped up.

In a population of one million in East Berlin, there were just 100,000 cars, or one to every ten inhabitants in 1970. That figure is unsurprising, given prospective Trabant owners needed saintly patience as waiting lists for cars ranged from three to seven years. Made from plastic sheets in place of steel for the doors, bonnet, boot and roof, Trabants were a virtual death trap. Add to that the fact that the brakes were weak, there was no petrol gauge or cooling system, and the consumption meter was useless. (A popular joke went thus: what do you call four Trabis at a crossroads? A Tupperware party!).

Strangely enough, Wartburg, the other famed GDR car, could be obtained without much trouble, while there was no waiting list for the unreliable Russian Moskvitch because so few people wanted to buy it. Paradoxically, the car famine led to a booming trade in second-hand motors, which – because of instant delivery – were often more expensive than new vehicles.